

Ratatosk's Muddled Message

The snowlit fjords of the north run deep and blue between white mountains and dark green pines, dotted with cosy longhouses whose windows glow warm amber against the snow. Above them arches the Great World Tree, and on clear nights the sky dances with the colours of the aurora. The fjords are full of gentle wonders: a chattering squirrel who carries messages along the tree, two thoughtful ravens, light spirits who dance in the dark, and frost giants who look fearsome but are mostly just cold and lonely. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who keeps a warm heart, dreams up ideas, and shares the fire. The grandest deeds are done by being brave and kind and full of ideas, and even a giant met with a friendly word often turns out lonelier than it is fierce.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.

Before you begin

The Great World Tree is huge. It goes from deep roots far below to a high nest right at the top. All day, a quick red squirrel runs up and down it, carrying everyone's messages. His name is Ratatosk.

But today something has gone wrong. Ratatosk has muddled all the messages up! Now the great Eagle at the very top thinks a small friend down in the roots said something unkind. And the small friend thinks the Eagle said something unkind too. Neither of them did. It was only a mix-up. But now the two old friends are cross, and the whole tree feels sad.

Edda the Saga-Keeper calls you to the warm Hearth Hall. "You have bright ideas and kind hearts," she says. "Will you help Ratatosk sort his messages and set things right, so the two friends are friends again?"

She gives you three gifts: a ball of red yarn, a snack for the squirrel, and a little lantern. Then she smiles. "Up here we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, kind, and full of ideas."



What is your hero name? Are you a hero of Imagination, of Courage, or of Heart?

Stop 1 Catch the Squirrel

You step out under the Great World Tree. There is Ratatosk, zooming up and down, round and round, far too flustered to stop. "Sorry, sorry, no time, all muddled!" he chatters as he whizzes past.

He is in such a flap that he cannot help anyone, not even himself. He needs to slow down and rest.



How could you help him feel calm? You have a snack for the squirrel. Could you sit very still and speak softly? Could you watch which way he runs and wait for the right moment?

When you hold out the snack and speak gently, Ratatosk stops at last. He nibbles, he breathes, and his little heart slows down. "Thank you," he sighs. "Now I can think."

Stop 2 Sort the Messages

Ratatosk opens his paws, and out tumble three little messages, all in a jumble. There are three friends waiting: the Eagle at the top, a kind old owl on a middle branch, and the small friend down in the roots. Each message belongs to one of them, but which goes where?

The Two Ravens, Thought and Memory, land beside you. They like to give a hint to heroes who try hard.



Can you remember who lives where? Read each message and look for a clue. One talks about the wind up high. One talks about the deep dark roots. One hoots a friendly hello. Which friend does each one belong to?

When you match every message to the right friend, the muddle melts away. "That's it! That's it!" cheers Ratatosk, clapping his little paws. Now you know exactly what to carry, and to whom.

Stop 3 Climb and Deliver

There is one more thing to do. The right message must go all the way up to the Eagle, and the right message all the way down to the small friend, so they each understand at last.

The tree is tall, and the climb is high. But you have your ball of red yarn.



How will you climb safely and not get lost? Could you tie the red yarn at the bottom, like a safety line, and follow it as you go? Could you light your little lantern for the dark deep roots?

When you tie on the red yarn and climb carefully, you reach the Eagle high above. You read out the kind, true message. The Eagle's fierce frown softens. "Oh!" he says. "So my friend was never unkind at all." Then you follow the yarn down, down, down to the roots, lantern glowing, and tell the small friend the same. The small friend's eyes go wide and happy.

Friends Again

The Eagle spreads his great wings and waves from the top of the tree. Far below, the small friend waves right back, and they both call out, "Friends again!"

Ratatosk runs a happy loop around the whole tree. "You sorted my muddle and mended my friends," he says. "Thank you, thank you!"

High above the snowy fjords, Freya the Kind looks down and smiles. You did it together. You were full of ideas, you were brave, and most of all, you were kind. Well done, heroes.

Ratatosk's Muddled Message: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle tale of a mix-up mended with kindness, and good ideas and care win every time. Nobody is unkind on purpose, and nothing here is ever truly broken, only muddled and put right again.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Hearth Hall.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady, warm heart), or **Heart** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a ball of string for the red yarn, a small snack or token for the squirrel's snack, and anything at all for a lantern. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Imagination and Heart together, say, or Courage and Imagination).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. In these fjords, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Nori the Tomte pops up and gives you one free hint.
2	You find your warm heart again, and take back one energy star.
3	A following wind down the tree, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Two Ravens, Thought and Memory, glide past and nod kindly. All is well.
5	A lucky knot in the red yarn: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A burst of hearth-warmth, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

There is no foe in this tale at all, only a muddle. The fierce-looking Eagle and the small friend in the roots are not enemies; they are old friends who have been hurt by crossed messages. The story is won not by beating anyone but by sorting the truth out and carrying the kind words to where they belong, so the two make up. Times spent puzzling out who said what, and carrying a kind message to a friend, sit happily alongside practice in memory, careful listening, and looking after others. Let the moment when the friends wave to each other land warmly; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

Ratatosk's Muddled Message: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: Catch the Squirrel (Easy)

The challenge. Ratatosk the Squirrel is zooming up and down the Great World Tree in a flustered panic, far too worked up to stop, listen, or help with anything. The players need to calm him and coax him to rest before the muddle can be sorted.

Intended solution. This is a Heart and Observation moment. The kind move is to slow right down themselves: sit still, speak softly, watch the way Ratatosk runs, and at the right moment offer the **snack** Edda gave them. A patient, gentle child who matches the squirrel's path and waits for him will win his trust quickly.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have Ratatosk pause for breath right beside them so the snack is easy to offer, or let them spend an energy star to call out something calming that he hears. Any genuine kindness settles him. Once he is calm, he sits, nibbles, and thanks them, and the story moves on.

Stop 2: Sort the Messages (Normal)

The challenge. Ratatosk tips out three jumbled messages. Three friends are waiting on the tree, and each message belongs to exactly one of them. The players must remember who lives where and match each message to the friend it belongs to, using a clue tucked inside each one.

The three friends. Read them aloud so the children can picture the tree: **the Eagle** lives at the very top, high in the wind and the wide sky; **the Owl** sits on a middle branch, friendly and fond of a hello; and **the small friend** lives far down among the deep dark roots.

The three messages and their clues. Read each message and let the children work out who it belongs to:

- "The wind is wild up here today, but I love the wide sky." The clue is **the wind and the high sky**, so this message belongs to **the Eagle** at the top.
- "It is cool and quiet and cosy down in the deep dark, just as I like it." The clue is **the deep dark roots**, so this message belongs to **the small friend** in the roots.
- "Whoo, hello, lovely to see a friend on my branch!" The clue is the friendly **hoot** from a **branch**, so this message belongs to **the Owl** in the middle.

Intended solution. This is a Memory, Logic and Vocabulary moment. The good move is to read each message, find the clue word (high sky, deep roots, a hoot), and match it to the friend who fits. Matching all three sorts the muddle. The **Two Ravens** are on hand to confirm a good guess or nudge a stuck one.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have a Raven read one message aloud again, slowly, and ask "Now, who likes the wind up high?" Sorting even one message starts the others falling into place, and getting there with the Ravens' help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: Climb and Deliver (Normal)

The challenge. The right message must travel all the way up to the Eagle and the right message all the way down to the small friend, so each hears the true words and the two understand each other again. The way up is high and the way down is deep and dark.

Intended solution. This is a Spatial and Heart moment. The thoughtful, careful move is to tie the **red yarn** at the bottom as a safety line and follow it up and back, so the climbers can always find their way, and to light the **little lantern** for the deep dark roots. Then comes the kind part: read each friend their true message warmly, so the Eagle and the small friend each realise the unkind words were never real, only a muddle.

Fallback. If the children feel the climb is too high, let Ratatosk scamper alongside to show the safest branches, or let them spend an energy star to climb hand in hand. If they are unsure what to say, the kind message can be as simple as "Your friend was never cross with you; it was all a mix-up." The moment the true words are spoken, the friend's frown turns to delight.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser, because there was never a foe, only a tangle of messages. When the right words reach the right friends, the Eagle high in the tree and the small friend down in the roots wave warmly to each other and call out, "Friends again!" Ratatosk thanks the heroes with a happy loop around the tree, and **Freya the Kind** smiles down from above the snowlit fjords. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, kind, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.